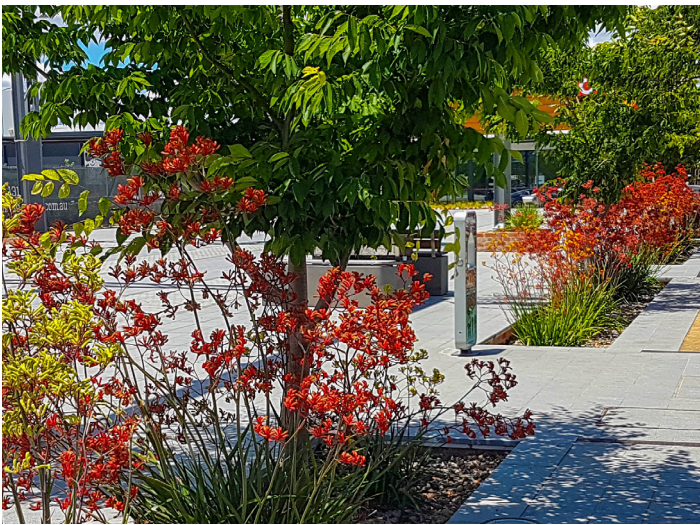
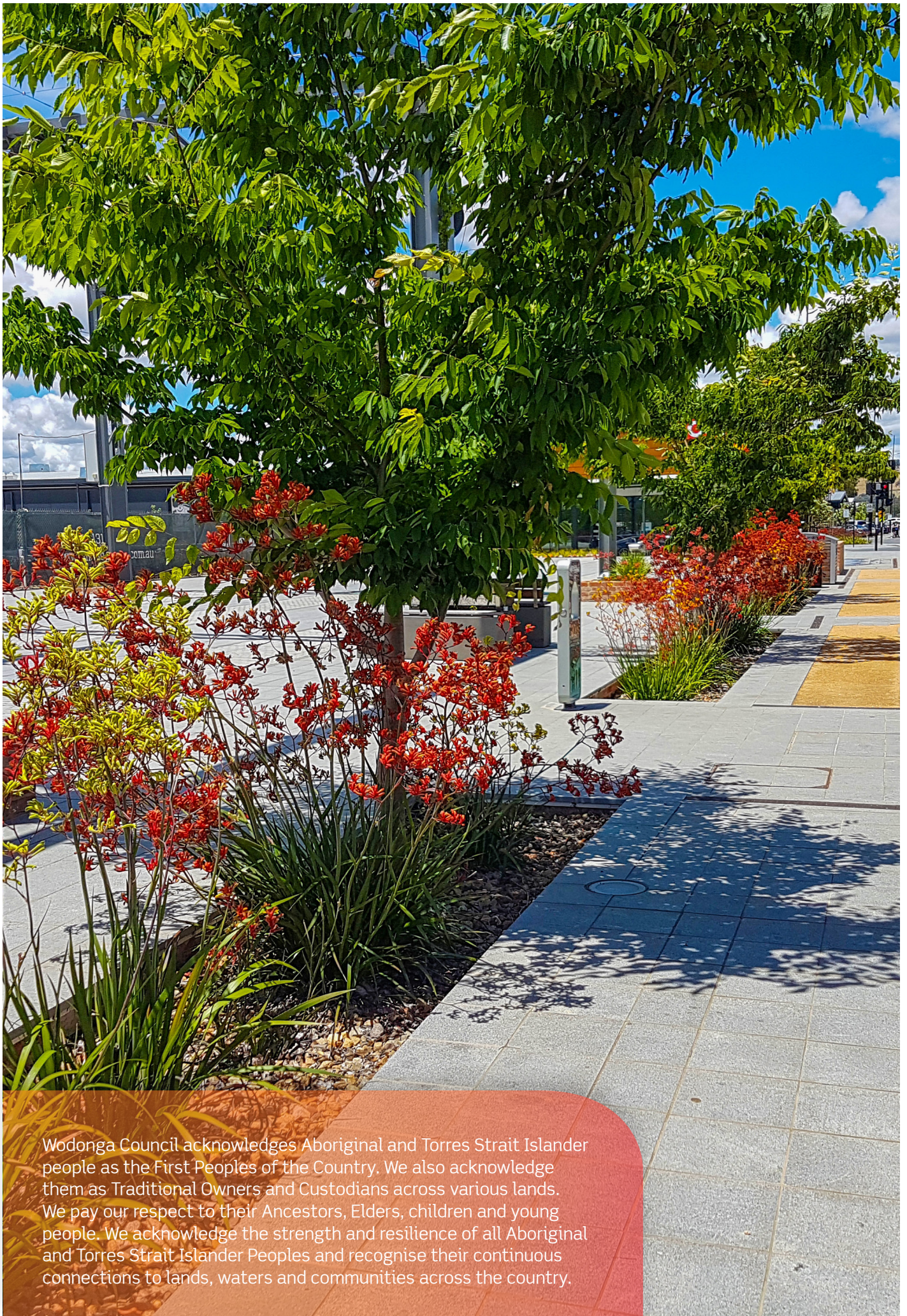




Extreme Heat Plan

Reviewed June 2025



Wodonga Council acknowledges Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people as the First Peoples of the Country. We also acknowledge them as Traditional Owners and Custodians across various lands. We pay our respect to their Ancestors, Elders, children and young people. We acknowledge the strength and resilience of all Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Peoples and recognise their continuous connections to lands, waters and communities across the country.

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The *Wodonga Heatwave (Extreme Heat) Plan*, reviewed June 2025, is a complementary plan of the *Municipal Emergency Management Plan 2024-2027*.

Amendment record

This plan is to be reviewed annually as set out in the Action Plan.

VERSION	DATE	AUTHOR	DETAILS
Version 1.0	April 2015	S Bennett P Leddy	Rewrite of plan
Version 2.0	October 2015	CEO	Endorsement of plan
Version 3.0	August 2017	S Bennett P Leddy	Addition of acronyms and update
Version 4.0	September 2018	P Leddy	Addition from North East Water and state arrangements
Version 5.0	October 2018	S Bennett P Leddy	Update legislative requirements and council information
Version 6.0	September 2019	S Bennett P Leddy	Review plan for summer season
Version 7.0	April 2022	S Bennett P Leddy	Review and update plan
Version 8.0	November 2023	H Carmichael P Leddy	Review and update plan
Version 9.0	April 2024	H Carmichael P Leddy K Gillison	Review and update plan
Version 10.0	June 2025	H Carmichael P Leddy K Gillison	Reviewed and name changed to Extreme Heat Plan

Extreme heat planning

Climate change is expected to increase the frequency and intensity of extreme heat events in Victoria. Extreme heat increases the incidence of illness and death, particularly among vulnerable population groups. It is important Wodonga Council develops, maintains and implements a municipal-wide approach to dealing with extreme heat events. The council's plan provides a framework to support the local community and vulnerable population groups so the city can be better equipped to handle more intense and frequent extreme heat events.

The *State Emergency Management Plan Extreme Heat Sub-Plan 2022* sets out arrangements to ensure an integrated and coordinated approach to the management of heat events, so as to reduce the impact and consequences of extreme heat events on the community, infrastructure and services. It sets out responsibilities, a collaborative approach to be taken by government and emergency management agencies, and planning and arrangements to be made by functional sectors of government and industry to prepare for an extreme heat event in order to reduce its impact on the community, infrastructure and services.

Legislation

The Victorian Government has a legislative framework relating to heat events. This includes:

- *Emergency Management Act 1986*;
- *Emergency Management Act 2013*;
- *Local Government Act 2020*;
- *Planning and Environment Act 1987*;
- *Public Health and Wellbeing Act 2008*; and,
- *State Emergency Management Plan Extreme Heat Sub-Plan 2022*.

The *Emergency Management Act 2013* outlines the governance arrangements in Victoria for managing all types of emergencies. The *Emergency Management Act 1986* outlines the responsibilities of local government to develop a municipal emergency management plan.

The *Planning and Environmental Act 1987* and the *Local Government Act 1989* ensure building codes and municipal strategic statements foster better planning of the built environment in order to withstand the impact of a range of likely emergencies.

The *Local Government Act 1989* also outlines the responsibility of local government to protect the public health in emergencies. The *Public Health and Wellbeing Act 2008* strengthens that role through municipal public health planning processes.

All Victorian councils are required to strive to meet the goals outlined in the *State Emergency Management Plan Extreme Heat Sub-Plan 2022*. These goals include:

- For councils to activate their extreme heat plans upon receipt of a Heat Health Warning (see extreme heat threshold diagram page 9) from the Chief Health Officer from the Department of Health. This will include enhanced actions from the pre-extreme heat phase;
- Contact at-risk Victorians to ensure their safety and wellbeing during an extreme heat event; and,
- Use local media and community services networks to inform and convey important information and advice on staying healthy in the heat to the Wodonga community.

The *Wodonga Extreme Heat Plan* sits alongside other council plans and strategies. It has clear links to the *Municipal Public Health and Wellbeing Plan 2025-2029* and the *Wodonga Council Plan 2025-2029*, and is a complementary plan to the *Municipal Emergency Management Plan*. It also falls under the state-wide extreme heat plan which details the different areas of response and action across government and the health and community sectors.

As part of the state plan, the *Wodonga Extreme Heat Plan* will be used by the council and its partners in the planning for, and responding to, extreme heat conditions. It has been developed using the general principles of emergency management as a guide to planning, preparation, response and recovery. See appendix one, summary of extreme heat actions. The plan is underpinned by a long-term approach by Wodonga Council, in partnership with stakeholders, to reduce the impact on the local community.

The *Wodonga Extreme Heat Plan* has been written to:

- Be consistent with the council's planning frameworks and guidelines;
- Outline health, community and emergency service actions and response arrangements to an extreme heat alert;
- Identify vulnerable persons within the Wodonga community;
- Propose a clear communication plan to initiate alert, response and recovery phases of the plan;
- Describe key stakeholder roles and responsibilities; and,
- Promote a community awareness and education component.

Why Wodonga needs an extreme heat plan

By developing Wodonga's own plan, the city can use its understanding of local conditions and resources to better prepare for, respond to and recover from heatwave conditions.

High temperatures can seriously impact the health of people in the municipality, especially the very young, the elderly, people with a chronic disease, those who work and play outdoors, and people on a low income. The council needs to be well-prepared in advance to make sure the community has the necessary tools to cope in times of extreme heat.

By having an extreme heat plan, the council can:

- Ensure that health information and support is readily available to the community;
- Increase the capacity of the community to respond during extreme heat conditions;
- Manage extreme heat emergencies more effectively; and,
- Develop long-term changes in behaviour to improve health and wellbeing.

The aim of the *Wodonga Extreme Heat Plan* is to:

- Support the Wodonga community to prepare for, respond to and recover from extreme heat conditions.

The council will achieve this by:

- Identifying vulnerable population groups in the community and the risks they face during extreme heat;
- Developing partnerships with local organisations to better coordinate a response to extreme heat;
- Outlining effective strategies and actions to implement in the event of extreme heat;
- Building practices to evaluate the ongoing effectiveness of the plan; and,
- Reviewing the plan annually, before the commencement of the summer season.

What Wodonga's community looks like

Location

Wodonga is located in the Ovens-Murray Statistical Division of Victoria, on the New South Wales border, about 300 kilometres north-east of Melbourne. It is bounded by the Murray River in the north, Towong Shire in the east and Indigo Shire in the south and west. The city itself encompasses the main urban centre of Wodonga, as well as significant rural hinterland and substantial industrial areas. It has a total land area of 434 square kilometres with the majority of the population living in urban areas. Rural land is used mainly for agriculture, including grazing and farming.

Population

Wodonga is one of Victoria's fastest growing provincial cities, experiencing unprecedented growth during the past 30 years. In 2025 it has an estimated residential population of 46,561 and is forecast to grow to 62,837 by 2046¹. Regionally, Wodonga services a population of more than 180,000 people, giving it a large critical mass.

From 2016 to 2021, Wodonga's population reflected a younger demographic, with the median age being 38 years. The largest age group is 30 to 34 years, with an higher number of under 18 years and lower number over 60 years compared with regional Victoria. There was also a notable increases in residents aged 70 to 79 years (41.6 per cent between 2016 and 2021)², and Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander population (50.7 per cent between 2016 and 2021)².

Lifestyle

Due to its relaxed, outdoor lifestyle and excellent facilities, Wodonga is a great place for people of all ages to live. Wodonga has more than 80km of bike and walking paths, providing the perfect opportunity to walk, cycle or jog by the river or around the city. Parks and gardens are dotted throughout the community and Wodonga's hillsides and parkland reserves provide bushwalking, cycling, bird watching and hiking tracks for the residents and visitors.

People living in Wodonga enjoy a range of community events and celebrations. The city is serviced by Hyphen - Wodonga Library Gallery, The Cube Wodonga, Bonegilla Migrant Experience, theatrical programs, exhibitions and community-generated activities.

Residents have access to a variety of quality health services from health care professionals and community services who work closely together to support the health needs of the area. Two funded health agencies, Albury Wodonga Health - Wodonga Campus and Gateway Health deliver a range of acute hospital, aged care, community and home-based support services. The council's maternal and child health (MCH) service is well attended by children.

Education is valued in Wodonga with seven kindergartens, a range of childcare centres, 11 primary schools (including a special development school for children with a disability), six secondary schools and the Flying Fruit Fly Circus School. Tertiary students have access to five post secondary education providers which include La Trobe University, Charles Sturt University, Wodonga Institute of TAFE, Riverina Institute of TAFE and the Albury Wodonga Community College.

Wodonga is also known as a child and family-friendly city and is committed to building a city where children and families feel connected and valued. It achieves this by partnering with a wide range of government departments, local services, community organisations, families and children to offer a diverse mix of quality family services and experiences.

1. Population and household forecasts, 2021 to 2046, National Forecasting Program, .id (informed decisions), February 2025.

2. .id community, City of Wodonga Community Profile

How extreme heat affects Wodonga

Wodonga, along with the rest of Victoria, experience high temperatures during the summer periods. The Victorian Government's Chief Health Officer estimates additional deaths will occur state-wide during extreme heat events.

Statistics also show a decline in the region's rainfall over the past decade. There were recorded fewer rainy days each year on average. It is predicted that the number of hot days will continue to increase and rainfall totals will continue to drop. As these predictions, in relation to climate change, are that extreme weather events are going to become more frequent and severe in the coming years. The council has a duty to ensure that all residents and services of Wodonga are well-prepared to protect the most vulnerable members of its communities during such events.

Currently, climate in the Wodonga area is typified by daily mean summer temperatures ranging from a minimum of 14°C to a maximum of 31°C. Mean daily winter temperatures range from a minimum of 2°C to a maximum of 12°C. Frosts can occur in Wodonga between April and October. Most rainfall occurs in winter and spring. Summer thunderstorms are common, contributing to the risk of fires and floods. On average, there are 97.4 days each year where at least one millimetre of rain falls.

The future climate of the Wodonga area is expected to be hotter and drier than it is today. By 2030, average annual temperatures are anticipated to be around 0.9°C warmer, with the smallest increases expected to be in winter (0.7°C). The number of hot days (days over 30°C) is also expected to increase. These climate change scenarios are dependent upon emissions growth in the region. Reductions in the total average annual rainfall of around 3 per cent are expected, with the greatest reductions occurring in spring (7 per cent). It is predicted over the coming years temperatures could increase to be above 2.9°C warmer, the number of hot days will continue to increase and rainfall totals will continue to drop.

Although average annual and seasonal rainfall is expected to decline slightly, the intensity of heavy daily rainfall is likely to increase in most seasons by 5 to 10 per cent. However, fewer rain days are anticipated with more droughts. These changes will increase the prevalence and extremity of extreme heat events



Extreme heat thresholds

In Victoria, extreme heat plans are activated by local councils when temperatures are forecast that are likely to impact on the health of the community. The Department of Health (Victoria) states that “an extreme heat event is where days of extreme heat and heatwaves are a period of unusually hot weather that can worsen medical conditions or cause potentially fatal health problems, like heatstroke. Extreme heat can affect everyone, however those more at risk are people over the age of 65, babies and young children, pregnant women, people with acute or chronic health problems, and people who are socially isolated. Extreme heat can also affect community infrastructure (such as power supply and public transport) and other services.”

The Bureau of Meteorology issues heatwave warnings when 10 per cent or more of a weather district is in a severe or extreme heatwave. It is based on three days of unusually high maximum and minimum temperatures for that location. More information from the Bureau of Meteorology is available on their website.

In Wodonga the extreme heat threshold is set at a mean temperature of 32°C over a 24-hour period, which is determined by calculating the daily maximum temperature and the overnight minimum and dividing them by two.

An example of how this calculation made is:

Tuesday

Min: 23°C

Max: 45°C

Wednesday

Min: 26°C

Max: 31°C

$$(45 + 26) / 2 = 35.5^{\circ}\text{C}$$

The threshold for Wodonga = mean of 32°C

Therefore, the temperature forecast indicates that the threshold will be exceeded.

The above calculation should be used to calculate the mean temperature of everyday within a seven day forecast which is available on the Bureau of Meteorology website: <http://www.bom.gov.au/vic/forecasts/map7day.shtml>

How extreme heat affects health

As temperatures rise, so too does the risk of contracting a heat-related illness, a medical condition that results from the body's inability to cope with heat and cool itself. If left untreated, a heat-related illness can lead to serious complications, even death. In fact, heat kills more people than tornadoes, hurricanes, lightning and flash floods combined.

Heat-related illness can make people feel uncomfortable, not so much because they feel hot, but rather because they sense how difficult it has become to lose body heat at the rate necessary to keep their inner body temperature close to 37°C. The body responds to this stress progressively through three stages as outlined in figure one below.

Figure one: Extreme heat affects on health

ILLNESS	SYMPTOMS	WHAT TO DO
Heat cramps	Muscle pains, spasms in the abdomen, arms or legs.	Stop activity and sit quietly in a cool place, increase fluid intake, rest a few hours before returning to activity, seek medical help if cramps persist.
Heat exhaustion	Pale complexion and sweating, rapid heart rate, muscle cramps, weakness, dizziness, headache, nausea, vomiting, fainting.	Get the person to a cool area and lay them down, remove their outer clothing, wet their skin with cool water or wet cloths, seek medical advice.
Heat stroke (A life-threatening emergency)	Same symptoms as heat exhaustion. Dry skin with no sweating, mental condition worsens, confusion, seizure, stroke-like symptoms or collapsing, unconsciousness.	Call an ambulance, get the person to a cool area and lay them down, remove their clothing, wet their skin with water, fanning continuously, position an unconscious person on their side and clear their airway.

Heat illnesses are preventable

High temperatures can also be related to:

- An increase in hospital admissions relating to heat stress, dehydration, or as a result of heat exacerbating existing conditions;
- Increased rates of certain crimes, particularly those related to aggressive behaviour such as homicide;
- Increased number of work-related accidents and reduced work productivity; and,
- Decreased sports performance.

To help prevent the onset of a heat-related illness, people in Wodonga are advised to:

- Carefully monitor the temperature and humidity outdoors, and plan activities and work hours accordingly by scheduling outdoor activities during cooler parts of the day;
- Stay in the shade or indoors in a cool location as much as possible;
- Drink plenty of water to replace fluids lost through sweating;
- Use a spray bottle to keep cool by misting;
- Wear lightweight loose-fitting and light-coloured clothing; and,
- Protect from the sun by wearing a hat and sunglasses, and using an umbrella.

General care for heat emergencies include cooling the body, giving fluids and minimising shock.

People most at risk of extreme heat conditions

Although anyone can suffer from the effects of prolonged periods of heat at any time, some people are at greater risk than others. Those most vulnerable include the elderly, infants and young children, people with a disability, people with a pre-existing medical condition and people who are socially and economically disadvantaged. Other groups at risk to heat include people who are overweight, people who over-exert during work or exercise, and people confined to bed and unable to care for themselves.

While Wodonga's *Extreme Heat Plan* plans for a whole-of-community response, it particularly focuses on those aged above 65 years of age, children between zero and 11 years of age, low-income earners, people with chronic disease, those with a disability, people on medication, those who work or play outdoors and visitors.

The elderly

From 2021 statistics, people in the over 60 age group comprised 23.4 per cent of the total Wodonga population. There were 10,105 Wodonga residents in this age group, an overall increase of 1983 elderly residents since 2016. Further analysis of the age structure of Wodonga shows that the two largest increases between 2016 and 2021 were in the age groups 70 to 84 (a further 1269 people) and 35 to 49 (a further 640 people)³.

Population forecasts for Wodonga show that the number of elderly residents will continue to increase. The two largest increases between 2021 and 2046 are forecast in the age groups 70 to 84 (a further 5338 people) and 35 to 49 (a further 3075 people)⁴.

Babies and young children

Babies and young children are particularly sensitive to the effects of high temperatures and can quickly become stressed by heat. They may not always show signs or symptoms even though they have been affected. They rely on others to control their environment and keep them from becoming dehydrated or overheated and it is very important to watch them closely.

In 2021, the Australian Bureau of Statistics Census recorded that there were 6918 children, or 16 per cent of the population aged zero to 11 years of age living in Wodonga³.

Wodonga's childcare centres and kindergartens have 'Sunsmart' policies to prevent heat-related illness and will disseminate extreme heat information provided by the council to their clients during stage two of the extreme heat strategy.

Low-income earners

The Socio-Economic Index for Areas (SEIFA) Australia index of disadvantage measures the relative level of socio-economic disadvantage based on a range of Census characteristics. It provides a general view of the relative level of disadvantage in one area compared to others, and is used to advocate for an area based on its level of disadvantage.

The index is derived from attributes that reflect disadvantage such as low-income, low educational attainment, high unemployment, and jobs in relatively unskilled occupations. When targeting services to disadvantaged communities, it is important to also look at these underlying characteristics as they can differ markedly between areas with similar SEIFA scores and shed light on the type of disadvantage being experienced.

3. Australian Bureau of Statistics, Census of Population and Housing 2016 and 2021. Compiled and presented by .id (informed decisions).

4. Population and household forecasts, 2021 to 2046, National Forecasting Program, .id (informed decisions), February 2025.

A higher score on the index means a lower level of disadvantage. A lower score on the index means a higher level of disadvantaged. In 2021, Wodonga's SEIFA score was 973, a score below several regional cities such as Ballarat (986) and Horsham (990), indicating higher socio-economic disadvantage, but scores higher than Greater Shepparton (944) and Mildura (940)⁵.

Research shows that low-income neighbourhoods tend to be hotter than their high-income counterparts during the summer. This can be attributed to low-income neighbourhoods tending to have more pavement and less substantial vegetation. This contributes to the so-called "heat island" effect where cities become giant heat sinks and radiators during the summer. Residents of low-income neighbourhoods are also less likely to have air-conditioning sufficient to counteract extreme heat.

In addition, some people who have air-conditioning won't use it because of the additional cost. Elderly residents in low-income areas, who make up the majority of victims during a heatwave, are less likely to leave their windows open due to safety concerns. The council continues to work collaboratively to develop strategies that assist those most vulnerable.

People with chronic disease

Virtually all chronic diseases present a risk of death/illness due to heat. Wodonga has high rates of some chronic diseases when compared with the rest of Victoria. The leading main disease groups contributing to the burden of disease in Wodonga include:

- Cancer;
- Cardiovascular disease;
- Dementia; and,
- Diabetes.

Other groups with chronic disease at increased risk of illness and death associated with heat include people with mental illness.

The prevalence of chronic disease and modifiable chronic disease risk factors have increased over time, in conjunction with increases in life expectancy. As the population ages, the number of people with a chronic disease in Wodonga is expected to increase. This presents a significant challenge to the health system with important implications for the future health and wellbeing of the population in periods of extreme heat.

People with a disability

Some people with a disability can be affected by heat because their body may not be able to regulate body temperature. This means the body may not be able to lose heat through skin by sweating or by having blood flow to the surface of the skin which helps the body to cool down. Excess fat or wearing too many clothes can also cause heat stress. Dehydration or not drinking enough water can cause heat stress as there may not be enough fluid in the body to facilitate sweating. Dehydration can also cause stress on the heart, known as cardiac stress.

A person with cognitive impairment, whether from disease or injury, may not be able to communicate distress. In some cases, they may not even "feel" the heat or discomfort because of changes in the brain's abilities to process sensory information or regulate their body's responses to heat.

5. Australian Bureau of Statistics, Census of Population and Housing 2016 and 2021. Compiled and presented by .id (informed decisions).

People on medication

Some medications increase the risk of heat stress. This varies according to the medication, for example:

- Antidepressants, antihistamines, phenothiazines and anticholinergics (used for some psychiatric conditions) act on an area of the brain that controls the skin's ability to make sweat;
- Beta blockers (heart tablets) reduce the ability of the heart and lungs to adapt to stresses including hot weather;
- Amphetamines raise body temperature;
- Diuretics (fluid tablets) act on the kidneys and encourage fluid loss. This can quickly lead to dehydration in hot weather; and,
- Opioids and sedatives can reduce the person's awareness of physical discomfort, which means symptoms of heat stress may be ignored.

People who are outdoors

Many people in Wodonga work and play outdoors in hot conditions, irrespective of the weather. Air temperature, radiant temperature, air velocity, humidity, clothing and activity are recognised as factors that interact to determine heat stress. Anyone having to work or play outside in hot weather without appropriate protection, particularly if this involves heavy physical activity, is at increased risk of suffering health effects from heat. Therefore, certain occupational and sporting groups need to be informed about possible measures to prevent heat stress, how to recognise heat stress, heat exhaustion and heatstroke, and what to do. Effective management systems for ensuring the health and safety of workers and sports people (especially children) must be in place.

Visitors

During heat events, heat stress can also be a risk for non-acclimatised visitors. Wodonga attracts large volumes of visitors, both national and international, per annum, with the majority transiting from Melbourne and Sydney via the Hume Freeway. These individuals are not influenced by traditional messaging as they are not necessarily traditional domestic radio listeners or television viewers.

Provision of managing heat health messaging and materials in relation to UV exposure, ensuring that they carry adequate water, wearing loose cool clothing and a hat, as well as using sun screen and reducing exercise in the hottest parts of the day can be accessed through social media messages.

Visitors should be aware of potable public water supplies. This is particularly important for the RV/motor home sector, where there is a need to fill 90 litres under floor water tanks for drinking, washing and cooling off purposes. Provision and advice regarding the location of taps and water availability is a key element of maintaining hydration and health during hot weather events is available through social media messaging services.

Other effects of extreme heat conditions

Energy

During a heat event, the demand for electricity can exceed the available supply and unplanned power outages may occur. Electricity distributors such as AusNet Services register addresses of power dependent people (life support customers). Customers who depend on electricity for life support equipment must inform their supplier to ensure immediate relief is provided.

Water

As per the *North East Water Heat Plan Statement*, heat events can cause an increase in the demand for water services, particularly drinking water. Concurrent risks can occur to distribution and treatment when power supply is also lost.

Water supply to the community is provided by a regulated reticulated system. North East Water, on behalf of Department of Energy, Environment and Climate Action (DEECA) will ensure appropriate preparation and response arrangements are in place for supply of safe drinking water, which includes:

- Maximising storage of drinking water;
- Rescheduling planned works to protect integrity of the reticulated system;
- Monitoring performance of water systems;
- Implementing timely repairs or controls for damaged or broken water supply infrastructure;
- Implementing business continuity arrangements for loss of power supply events; and,
- Providing the Regional Control Team (RCT) consequence information for any loss of supply or loss of services to vulnerable or critical community services.

Animals

Animals must be cared for in a heat event. The *Wodonga Municipal Emergency Animal Welfare Plan 2024* (available on the council's website) outlines the responsibilities, interactions and activities provided to ensure animals are cared for.

What the council is going to do

The *Wodonga Extreme Heat Plan* will be used to be better prepared for and respond to heatwave conditions during the summer months. Wodonga Council will:

- Plan for and respond to extreme heat conditions;
- Include extreme heat preparation, response and recovery into existing municipal plans;
- Support strategies that contribute to reducing the effect of climate change and improve household energy efficiency;
- Maintain green, shady spaces in the city;
- Work with community services and organisations to support vulnerable populations;
- Engage in a communication and media campaign using extreme heat messages consistent with the Department of Health materials;
- Respond to the state activated heat health warning system in a planned and considered way; and,
- Promote the use of cool areas in key locations around the city.

The action plan

The core elements of the extreme heat plan can be divided into three stages summarised in figure two below and outlined in appendix one.

Figure two: Three stages of extreme heat planning

STAGE 1	Pre-summer preparation
STAGE 2	During summer prevention
STAGE 3	Extreme heat response

Each stage is characterised by a set of key actions (see figure three).

What the council does in stage one

Stage one of the extreme heat plan occurs between April 1 and November 30 and requires the implementation of pre-summer actions. The best defence to heat-related illness is prevention. Its major components include the groundwork supporting an extreme heat awareness campaign, identifying vulnerable groups and cool areas, and engaging key partners. During this stage the extreme heat plan will be reviewed with any necessary changes or possible improvements made.

Extreme heat awareness campaign

People living through a summer in Wodonga need to be informed adequately about extreme heat events. This includes information about risk characteristics, preventative measures, and appropriate behaviours during extreme heat (as outlined in figure three) and an understanding of their own responsibility to be prepared. Wodonga Council will use the same key health messages as recommended by the Department of Health to prepare the general public and vulnerable groups in the community for the upcoming summer. The campaign will involve simple, specific tips around how to prevent and identify the symptoms of heat-related illness and provide advice on the appropriate actions to take if a person exhibits signs of a heat-related illness (as outlined in figure one).



As older people, young children, low-income earners, people with a chronic disease and outdoor workers and sports people have been identified as vulnerable groups during heatwaves, messages and resources will be used to particularly target these groups and their carers, employers and supporting organisations. Wodonga Council will use the electronic templates made available from the department and will distribute them through community services and organisations. A range of materials such as posters and brochures will be made available during this time. It will be a standalone campaign so that mixed messages are not relayed.

Identify vulnerable groups and update community registers

Key stakeholders who interact directly with vulnerable clients will be encouraged during stage one to maintain, as part of their individual care and response plan, a community register within their organisation or group. The registers will provide an opportunity to share public health information about extreme heat and heat-related illnesses to those who have enrolled voluntarily. In the event of a declared extreme heat event, this register would be used to phone high risk people, activate community phone trees and remind neighbours to check on each other every day during extreme heat.

Agencies responsible for assisting people on the Vulnerable Person's Register (VPR) will be encouraged to develop support plans for extreme heat conditions. The council will be responsible for updating the VPR.

We advise, if you have not seen your neighbour for a while, to contact the Wodonga Police.

Identify cool areas

In the event of extreme heat it is recommended the public source cool areas. Easily accessible areas include public swimming pools, libraries, some community centres, local shopping centres and other areas. The council may identify and consider opening community spaces for people to attend to escape from the heat and may consider extending pool operating hours. Recommended cool areas, including the local pool opening hours, will be advertised by the council through council's regular communication channels.

Engage key stakeholders

Successful implementation of the extreme heat plan is dependent upon key stakeholders understanding their role in the event of a declared extreme heat event in Wodonga. Stakeholders will have different responsibilities according to the stage of the plan and context of the extreme heat conditions. They will be reminded of these in stage one. Key stakeholders are encouraged to have their own extreme heat plans where possible and appropriate. A list of stakeholders is included in appendix three.

What key stakeholders can do in stage one

In stage one key stakeholders will be advised by the council to consider:

- Revisiting their actions from the previous summer and evaluate their levels of effectiveness;
- Meeting with other stakeholders to revise and amend key heatwave messages and actions;
- Reviewing heat health alert protocols for workplace supervisors and staff;
- Updating their community registers;
- Preparing and revising pre-prepared key heat messages;
- Identify cool areas within each group's control which could be promoted to the general public during the awareness campaign;
- Restocking heat health information in relevant places;
- Participating in the Department of Health's Extreme Heat Awareness Campaign;
- Educating any staff of key extreme heat messages (especially customer service staff); and,
- Assist vulnerable persons to include heat health planning in personal emergency management plans.

What the council does in stage two

Stage two includes a range of actions to further build resilience among Wodonga residents during the summer months. It directly involves the actions of most key stakeholders. This stage is implemented between December 1 and March 31 each year.

Implement the Extreme Heat Awareness Campaign

The campaign will provide key heat/health messages to the community during this time via council's regular communication channels. These will include those outlined in figure three below.

Figure three: Key heat health messages

COOL YOUR HOME DOWN	STAY OUT OF THE HEAT	KEEP YOURSELF COOL AND HYDRATED	WHAT YOU CAN DO FOR OTHERS
• Keep windows that are exposed to the sun closed during the day and open at night when the temperature has cooled; • Turn off non-essential lights and electrical equipment; • Move to the coolest room to sleep.	• Keep out of the sun during the hottest part of the day; • Avoid extreme physical exercise; • Wear light, loose fitting clothes; • Reschedule essential appointments to early morning.	• Drink plenty of water and avoid caffeine or alcohol; • Take a cool shower; • Spray water over your skin or clothing; • Keep a damp cloth on the back of your neck.	• Phone or visit elderly or sick family/ neighbours; • Be aware of phone numbers you can ring to get help; • Know where cool places are in the area.

In stage two the council will:

- Advise key stakeholders to implement stage two of their plans. Sporting bodies and summer event organisers will also be informed of safe heat thresholds;
- Ensure designated cool areas within the city are ready for use in the event of an extreme heat event. Public pools will be informed of stage three actions. Air-conditioning and water access will be checked at key locations. Extra water will be provided to Hyphen - Wodonga Library Gallery; and,
- Monitor BOM thresholds for Wodonga for daily weather updates.

What key stakeholders can do in stage two

In stage two key stakeholders will be advised by the council to consider participating in the Department of Health's Extreme Heat Awareness Campaign by:

- Identifying cool areas and access to water;
- Keeping in regular contact with vulnerable clients;
- Modifying client programs; and,
- Rescheduling staff work hours.

What the council does in stage three

Stage three is triggered when imminent extreme heat temperatures are predicted by the Bureau of Meteorology (BOM) for Wodonga. The council will know to move to this stage when it is notified by the Department of Health. Two staff members at the council, the Manager Business Services and the Team Leader Environmental Health, will receive an email alert on the day when forecasted temperatures first exceed threshold levels. It will then be up to the council to continue to monitor forecast temperatures in the area and notify the relevant partners to activate stage three of this extreme heat plan.

Efficient implementation of stage three is dependent upon Wodonga Council, informing all key partners of their responsibilities to enact stage three of their extreme heat plan via email or phone. The communication plan below will be followed to ensure this process is carried out smoothly and effectively.

What key stakeholders can do in stage three

Prompt action by stakeholders during stage three will ensure the impacts of heat on vulnerable groups are kept to a minimum. All key stakeholders will be advised by the council to consider:

- Contacting those listed on the Vulnerable Person's Register or community registers by phone;
- Developing support plans for extreme heat conditions for vulnerable clients;
- Prioritising tasks and clients;
- Assessing risk for clients and staff;
- Rescheduling staff work times and hours;
- Providing additional fluids for clients and staff;
- Modifying client programs;
- Transporting clients in cooler parts of the day;
- Cancelling sporting fixtures;
- Assessing risk when releasing vulnerable patients from hospital; and,
- Altering children's outdoor activities and play times.

Partners

Wodonga Council, in partnership with the Department of Health—the control agency for Class 2 emergencies related to extreme heat—will provide key messages and important information on extreme heat events. These communications will align with the Chief Health Officer’s public health messaging and communication resources and will be shared with residents over the summer period. The council outlines how these messages are distributed, disseminated, and worded in the *Extreme Heat Plan: Action and Communication Plan* in Appendix Two.

The council’s extreme heat plan is managed by the Emergency Management Coordinator. The council will work alongside partners from within the Wodonga community to act as key partners in extreme heat planning. The council will partner with government, private sector, service provider and community group organisations that represent Wodonga’s vulnerable communities. These partners will include:

- Aged care providers (public and private)
- Albury Wodonga Aboriginal Health Service
- Albury Wodonga Ethnic Communities Council
- Albury Wodonga Health - Ovens Murray Public Health Unit
- Albury Wodonga Health - Wodonga campus
- AusNet Services
- Community service providers (Senior Citizens’ Association, Wodonga childcare centres and playgroups, churches, Salvation Army, St John Ambulance)
- Department of Families, Fairness and Housing
- Department of Health
- Department of Veteran Affairs
- Department of Energy, Environment and Climate Action (DEECA)
- Educational institutions
- Emergency Recovery Victoria
- Emergency services (Victoria Police, SES, CFA, Fire Rescue Victoria, Ambulance Victoria, Red Cross)
- Gateway Health
- Junction Support Services
- Mungabareena Aboriginal Corporation
- Murray Primary Health Network
- Recreation organisations
- Upper Murray Family Care
- Victorian Council of Churches (Emergency Management)
- Wodonga pharmacies

Each of these partners has an important role to play in the event of a declared extreme heat event in Wodonga. Their interactions are outlined in appendix two. The council has consulted with its partners and identified four areas of priority considered as crucial to the development of an effective extreme heat plan. These include:

1. The formulation of localised plans and interventions based upon sound research and results of community consultation;
2. The targeting of vulnerable groups and the building of networks within the community;
3. Health promotion and community education; and,
4. Encouraging resilience.

Victoria Police plays a supporting role in regional coordination and broader emergency management functions but is not the control agency for heat-related emergencies.

How the council evaluates the plan's effectiveness

To ensure the *Wodonga Extreme Heat Plan* remains relevant and meets the changing needs of the community, the council will review the plan annually before each summer and use any amendments to inform an updated plan every four years. All relevant partners will actively participate in the evaluation.

The following will be reviewed:

- Stakeholders
- Department of Families, Fairness and Housing heatwave data, strategies and communication tools
- Were the actions in stage three appropriate and timely
- What worked
- What didn't work
- Was information communicated effectively to partners
- Was information communicated effectively to the general community
- What could be done differently next summer

The three stage communication plan is outlined in appendix two.

Appendix one

Summary of extreme heat plan actions

STAGES	ACTIONS	WHO IS RESPONSIBLE
STAGE ONE Pre-summer preparation April 1 to November 30	Implement extreme heat awareness	Manager Business Services
	Identify vulnerable groups and update community register (April to November)	Manager Business Services
	Identify cool areas (April to November)	Manager Business Services
	Restock heat health information in public places. GP clinics, community health, shopping centres, libraries and swimming pools (April to November)	Manager Business Services
	Engage key partners (April to November)	Manager Business Services
STAGE TWO During summer prevention December 1 to March 31	Implement Department of Health's Extreme Heat Awareness Campaign (December to March)	Manager Business Services
	Advise key partners of roles and responsibilities	A/A and MEMP committee and Emergency Management Co-ordinator
	Organise cool areas for possible use if applicable	Manager Business Services
	Monitor BOM reports for Wodonga	Manager Business Services
STAGE THREE Extreme heat response trigger: Department Health heat alert	Implement extreme heat action plan following a heat health warning	Manager Business Services
	Advise key partners to enact specific actions	Manager Business Services- All stakeholders - Emergency Management Coordinator
	Promote cool areas	Manager Business Services - All stakeholders
	Inform emergency management team	Manager Business Services
	Campaign (April to November)	Manager Business Services - Communications
	Monitor BOM and Department of Health reports	Manager Business Services

Appendix two

Extreme Heat Plan: Action and Communication Plan

Scope:

Wodonga Council's *Extreme Heat Plan* determines how the council will support the local community to adapt and minimise the impact of extreme heat.

Objectives:

- Support the community to prepare for, respond to and recover from extreme heat events;
- Develop long-term changes in behaviour to improve health and wellbeing;
- Identify vulnerable population groups in the community and the risks they face during extreme heat events;
- Develop partnerships with local organisations to better coordinate a response to extreme heat events;
- Ensure health information and support is readily available to the community;
- Increase the capacity of the community to respond during extreme heat events; and,
- Provide information and advice in a timely and appropriate manner to identified stakeholders.

Actions and responsibilities are set out below.

	TIMEFRAME	ACTION	HOW	RESPONSIBLE PERSON
Prepare	September/ October	Review of extreme heat plan		Manager Business Services All stakeholders
	October	Distribute resources to key locations and restocking heat health information	Maternal and Child Health Centres/ Kindergartens	Manager Child and Family Services
			Library	Manager Community Development
			Sporting facilities	Manager Community Development
	October	Publish keeping cool messages (as outlined in figure four)	Council's communication channels	Manager Business Services
			Active News	Manager Community Development
		Meeting with other stakeholders to revise and amend key extreme heat messages and actions	Those identified in appendix three	Manager Business Services

	TIME FRAME	ACTION	HOW	RESPONSIBLE PERSON
Prepare	October to December 1	Stage one	Update Vulnerable Person's Register	Manager Business Services
			Review Department of Health supplied key extreme heat messages	Emergency Management Coordinator Manager Business Services
			Review and update the council website, as necessary	Emergency Management Coordinator Manager Business Services
			The council will identify and consider community spaces to promote to the general public as cool areas during the awareness campaign	Emergency Management Coordinator
			Review extreme heat alert protocols for workplace supervisors and staff and educate staff	Manager People, Safety and Customer Experience
			Ensure all persons on the VPR are aware of the activation of stage one	Emergency Management Coordinator

	TIME FRAME	ACTION	HOW	RESPONSIBLE PERSON
React	December 1 to March 31	Stage two	Council advised of Heat Health Warning	Chief Medical Officer, Department of Health
			Advise key stakeholders to implement stage two of their plans	Emergency Management Coordinator
			Activate the Department of Health's Extreme Heat Awareness Campaign	Emergency Management Coordinator Manager Business Services
			Activate and organise cool areas if applicable and publicise	Manager Community Development
			Ensure all persons on the VPR are aware of the activation of stage two	Emergency Management Coordinator
			Rescheduling staff work hours	All managers
			Monitor BOM thresholds for Wodonga for daily weather updates	Emergency Management Coordinator
	December 1 to March 31	Stage three	The council advises all key internal and external stakeholders to implement stage three of their extreme heat plan	Emergency Management Coordinator
			Ensure all persons on the VPR are aware of the activation of stage three	Emergency Management Coordinator
			Prioritising tasks and clients	All managers
			Assessing risk for clients and staff	All managers
			Rescheduling staff work times and hours	All managers
			Providing additional fluids for clients and staff	All managers
			Modifying client programs	All managers
			Keeping in regular contact with vulnerable clients	Emergency Management Coordinator Victoria Police
			Altering children's outdoor activities and play times, and advise sporting clubs	Manager Early Years and Family Services Manager Community Development
			Cancel any council outdoor events	Manager Cultural Services

	TIME FRAME	ACTION	HOW	RESPONSIBLE PERSON
Recover		Post event	Review	Director Community and Corporate Manager Business Services Emergency Management Coordinator
			Revise	Director Community and Corporate Manager Business Services Emergency Management Coordinator
			Replenish, restock extreme heat health information in relevant places	All managers

Appendix three

Stakeholder interactions

Stage three communication plan

